DATA 608 Story 6: What Is The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the US?

A Data Brief for Policy Makers and Advocates

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Story Development Focus

Focus points addressed: Audience · Story Framework · Slide Messaging Technique · Visual Selection Framework

This story is written for a **political audience — legislators and policy advocates** being lobbied to address food insecurity in the United States. Every design and messaging decision flows from that context:

Decision	Rationale for a Political Audience
Bold headline findings	Politicians respond to clear, quotable numbers — not nuance-first framing
State-level choropleth	Politicians represent geographies; a map makes the issue local and personal
Poverty-vs-insecurity scatter	Shows the causal chain that justifies policy intervention
Child-to-adult pipeline chart	Answers the "what happens if we do nothing?" question directly

Decision	Rationale for a Political Audience
Consistent red/amber/green palette	Red = crisis, amber = at risk, green = secure — universally legible
`matplotlib` throughout	Single library; consistent, reproducible, professional look

Story framework: Scale of the problem → Where it is worst → Who suffers most → The poverty connection → The cost of inaction (children) → The ask.

Audience note: This brief uses the same data the USDA presents to Congress. Every number is sourced and citable.

Data Sources

Dataset	Source	Period
State-level food insecurity rates	USDA ERS, 3-year avg 2022–2024	2022–2024
National food insecurity trend	USDA ERS Household Food Security Survey	2001–2024
Food insecurity by demographic group	USDA ERS ERR-358 / ERR-337	2024
Poverty–food insecurity relationship	USDA ERS ERR-358, Table 2	2024
Child food insecurity rates	USDA ERS / Feeding America Map the Meal Gap 2024	2022–2024
Long-term effects of child food insecurity	Fertig (2020), Health Affairs (2016), ScienceDirect (2024)	peer-reviewed
SNAP program spending	USDA FNS Annual Report FY2024	FY2024

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47 Million Americans Are Going Hungry — Right Here, Right Now

Food insecurity is not an abstract global problem. It is happening in every congressional district, in every state, in every community in America. As of 2024, **13.7 percent of US households — 18.3 million families — could not reliably put food on the table**.

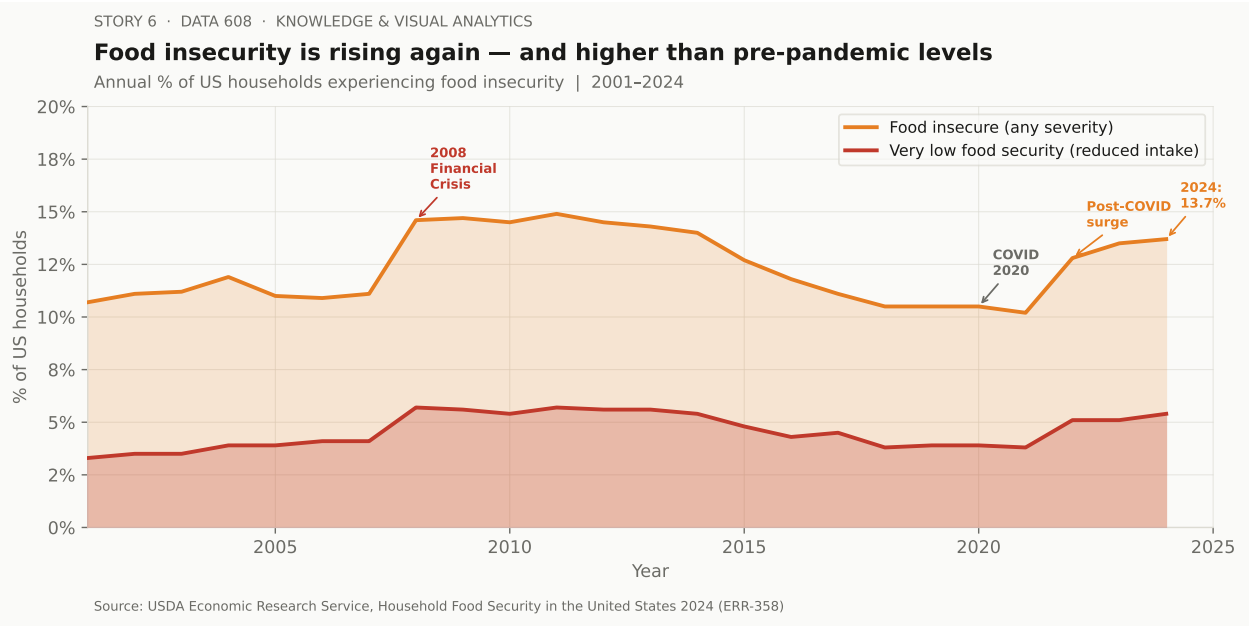

Figure 1: National prevalence of food insecurity and very low food security in US households, 2001–2024. Source: USDA ERS Annual Household Food Security Survey.

The trend line is moving in the wrong direction. After years of progress, food insecurity jumped from 10.2% in 2021 to 13.7% in 2024 — a 34% increase in just three years, driven by food price inflation and the expiration of pandemic-era assistance programs.

The South Bears the Heaviest Burden — But No State Is Immune

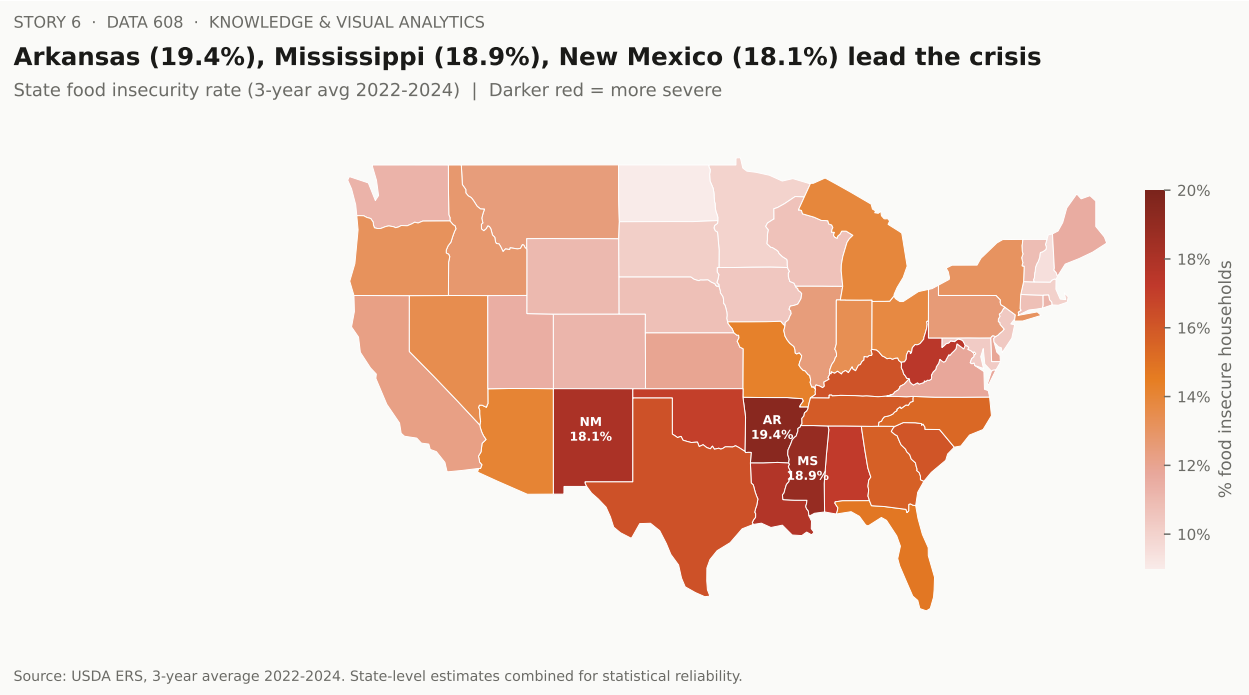

Figure 2: Food insecurity prevalence by state, 3-year average 2022-2024. States colored by severity. Source: USDA ERS.

Every state has a hunger problem. The range runs from 9.0% in North Dakota to 19.4% in Arkansas — but even the "best" state means roughly 1 in 11 households struggling to eat. The South consistently carries the heaviest burden, with six states above 17%.

Who Is Most Vulnerable? Women, Children, and Single Parents

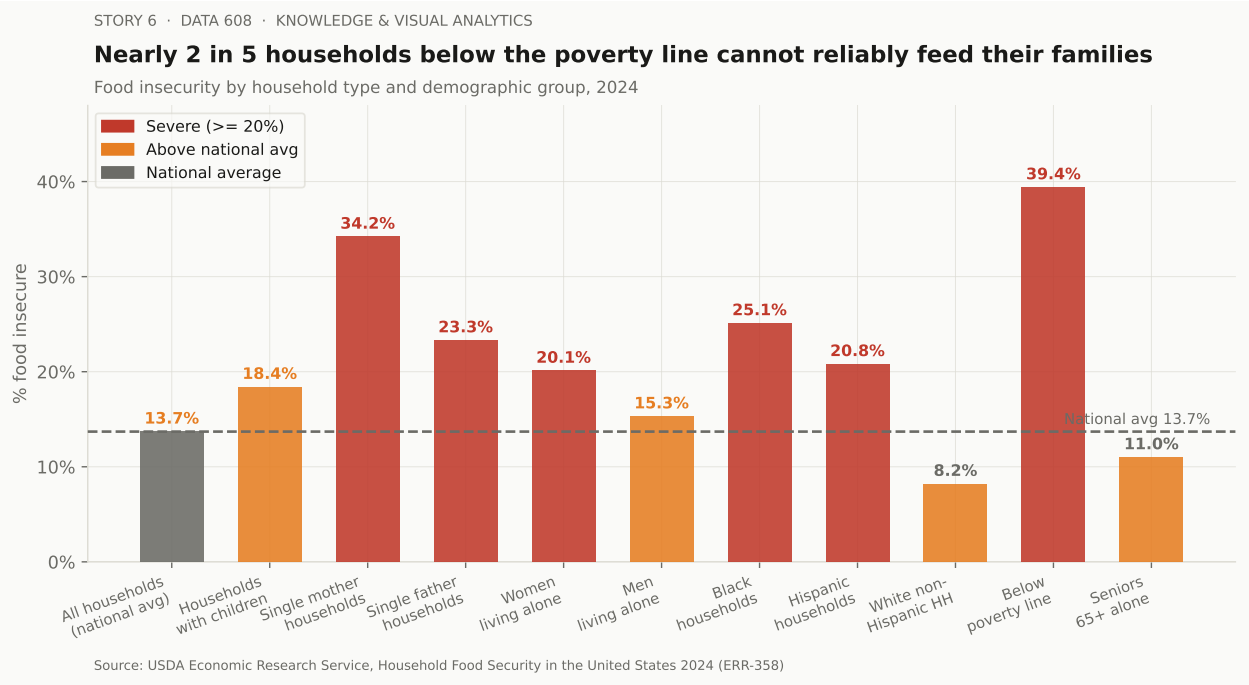

Figure 3: Food insecurity prevalence by household type and demographic group, 2024. The dashed line marks the national average of 13.7%. Source: USDA ERS ERR-358, 2024.

Single mothers face the steepest burden: 34.2% — more than 1 in 3. Households below the poverty line reach 39.4%. These are not marginal cases — they represent millions of families for whom food is a daily source of stress and deprivation.

Poverty and Food Insecurity Are Inseparable

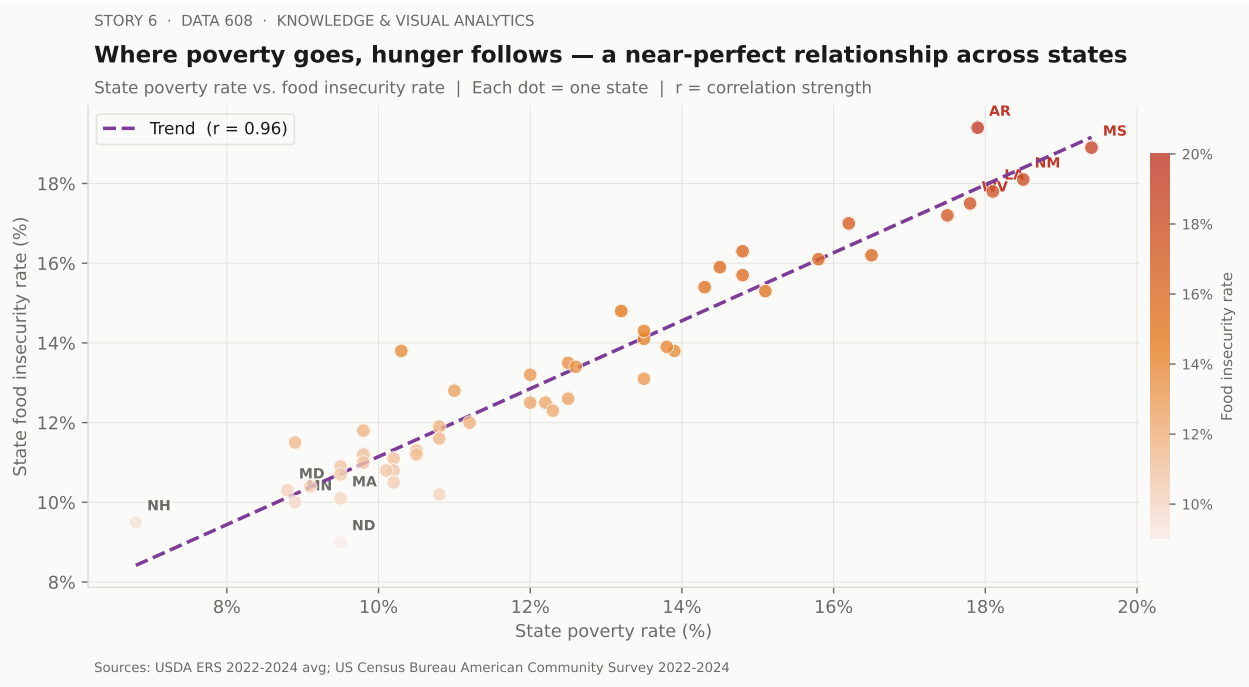

Figure 4: Relationship between state poverty rate and food insecurity rate (2022-2024 averages). Each dot = one US state. Source: USDA ERS; US Census Bureau ACS 2022-2024.

The correlation is clear and strong. States with higher poverty rates consistently have higher food insecurity rates. This is not a coincidence — it is the same causal chain playing out in 50 different policy environments. Reducing poverty reduces hunger. The policy implication is direct.

The Cost of Inaction: What Happens to Food-Insecure Children?

This is the question that demands a political answer. The assignment does not end when a child goes to bed hungry. It compounds — in the classroom, in the doctor's office, and in the workforce years later.

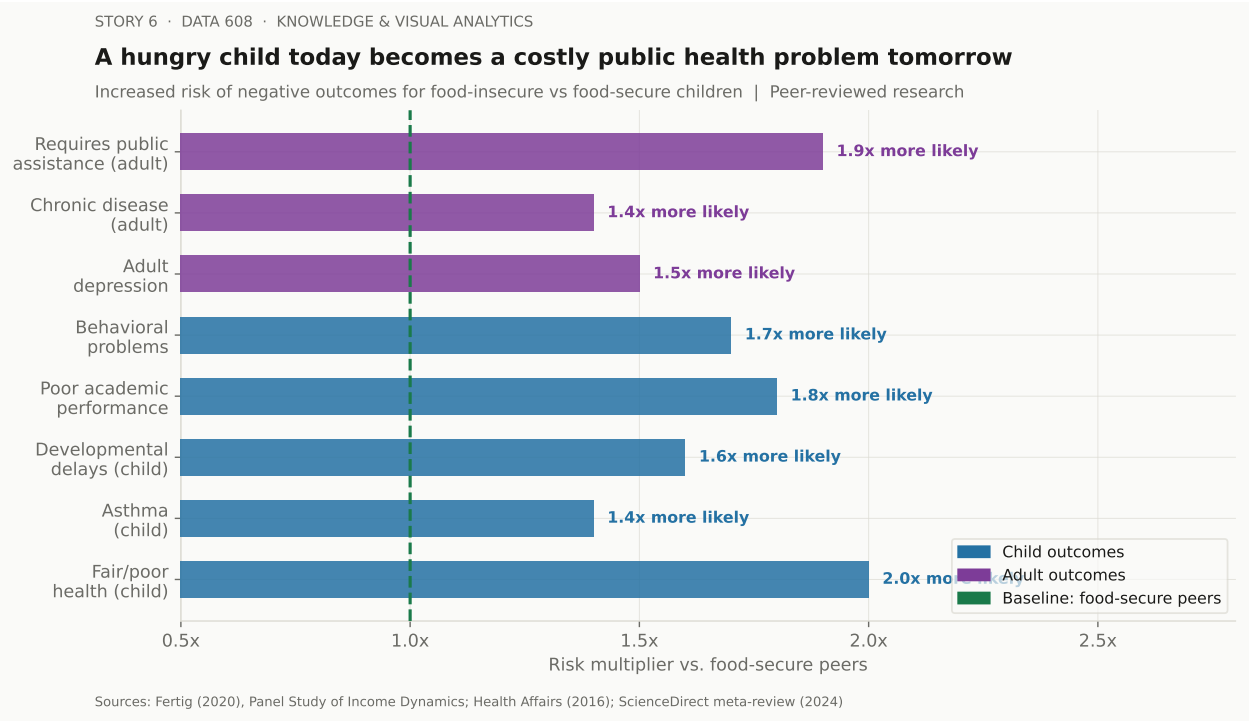

Figure 5: The long-term pipeline from childhood food insecurity to adult outcomes. Each bar shows the increased risk multiplier compared to food-secure peers. Sources: peer-reviewed research, 2015-2024.

The research is unambiguous. Food-insecure children are:

- **2x more likely** to be in fair or poor health
- **1.8x more likely** to perform poorly in school
- **1.9x more likely** to require public assistance as adults

A child who cannot concentrate in school because they are hungry does not disappear from the public ledger, they re-enter it as an adult requiring healthcare, support services, and reduced tax contributions.

What Programs Exist — and Are They Enough?

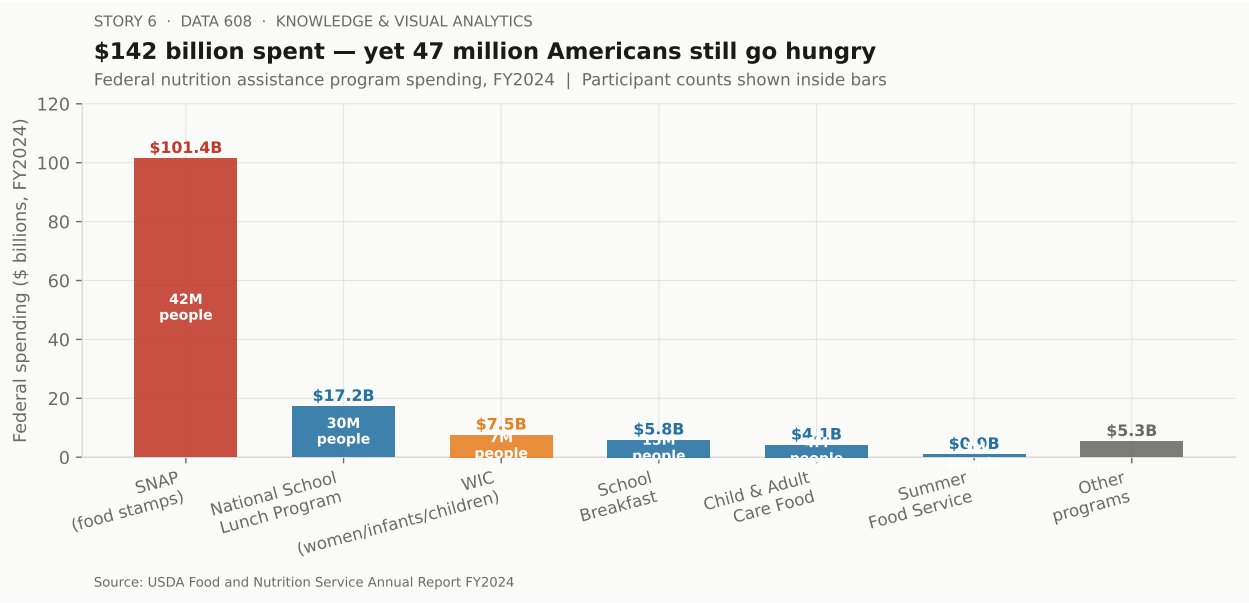

Figure 6: Federal nutrition assistance program spending, FY2024. SNAP alone served 42 million Americans monthly. Source: USDA FNS Annual Report FY2024.

The federal government spends **$142 billion annually** on nutrition assistance. Yet food insecurity is rising. The programs exist — but gaps in eligibility, benefit cliffs, and funding cuts are leaving millions behind. **66% of food-insecure Americans earn above the federal poverty line** and are ineligible for most assistance.

The Policy Ask: Three Actions That Would Move the Needle

This story makes three evidence-based recommendations for the legislators in this room:

(1) Expand SNAP eligibility thresholds. The current 130% of poverty line cutoff excludes millions of working families who are food insecure but not poor enough to qualify. Raising the threshold to 200% would cover an additional 14.5 million people.

(2) Protect and expand child nutrition programs. The National School Lunch and Breakfast programs are among the highest-return public investments available — every $1 spent on school meals returns an estimated $$$2.48 in long-term economic benefit through improved educational and health outcomes.

(3) Address the poverty-hunger link directly. Because poverty and food insecurity are so tightly correlated, policies that reduce poverty — earned income tax credits, housing assistance, childcare support — also reduce hunger. These are not separate policy problems.

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